Lower MS Filmmaking Syllabus

Younger Middle School · Grades 5–6

2026–2027

INSTRUCTOR INFORMATION

Instructor	Email	Room Location & Hours
Luke Hegelund	Luke@rivertech.me	Dance Hall — Tuesdays, 10:25–11:05 AM

GENERAL INFORMATION

Description

The goal of this class is not to cover a filmmaking curriculum. The goal is to make filmmaking fun enough that students keep filming at home, and then to keep giving them tools, challenges, and reasons to do it.

How a Week Runs

Two formats alternate, along with the ongoing quarter project:

- Shoot week: 5 min watching student films from the screening queue, 5 min inspiration clip and intro, 25 min shooting, 5 min quick edit and watch.
- Edit week: 5 min watching student clips, 35 min editing and watching last week's film, with extra time spent teaching editing technique.

The class shoots as one group with Mr. Luke directing. There are no assigned crew roles — everyone is on camera, and helper jobs are volunteered. All class footage is cut on Mr. Luke's laptop and projected, with a student driving; nothing transfers to student devices.

Expectations and Goals

Students are expected to participate fully in the weekly in-class shoot or edit, and are encouraged (though not required beyond a floor of two submissions per quarter) to film short films at home with friends and family. Every week ends with one home challenge that can be done on a phone.

COURSE MATERIALS

Required Materials

- CapCut (free) — the class default, set up together in Week 1
- A phone or tablet for home filming (school equipment is used for in-class shoots)

Optional Materials

- iMovie or Clipchamp — fallback editors if CapCut isn't available

- DaVinci Resolve — for students who want to go further

COURSE SCHEDULE

Quarter 1 (Sept.–Oct.): Foundations & Core Techniques

Week	Activity	Notes
1 — Sept. 1	Launch and Setup — syllabus, rivertech.me, install and demo CapCut, how to film at home, favorite films	Award criteria posted
2 — Sept. 8	One Angle Versus Many — an argument scene shot on one locked angle, then in coverage	—
3 — Sept. 15	Cut It and Score It (edit week) — cut both versions, compare, then record and layer foley	—
4 — Sept. 22	Buffer week — absorbs overruns; otherwise a challenge off the bench	—
5 — Sept. 29	Silent Film Then Change Everything — music and color grade change the meaning of the same footage	Quarter Challenge announced
6 — Oct. 6	Invisibility Cloak — green screen	—
7 — Oct. 13	Cockpit, part one — the whole class in chairs, Star Wars style	—
8 — Oct. 20	Cockpit, part two — compositing	—
9 — Oct. 27	Showcase — class ranking, awards, and the class reel	—

Quarter 2 (Nov.–Jan.): TBD

Quarter 3 (Jan.–Apr.): TBD

Quarter 4 (Apr.–May): TBD

ASSIGNMENT SCHEDULE

Date	Subject
Sept. 1	Software setup (CapCut) and award criteria posted
Sept. 29	Quarter Challenge announced
Sun., Oct. 25	Quarter Challenge due
Oct. 27	Showcase — class ranking, awards, and class reel

HOME FILMS

Students are encouraged to film short films at home and email them to luke@rivertech.me — either attached, or as a Google Drive or YouTube link. The email must name everyone who worked on the film and say what the student personally did; collaboration and parent help are both allowed.

Two films are screened in class per week, first come, and the queue carries over from week to week. Every student who reaches a screening gets gold.

QUARTER CHALLENGE & AWARDS

The Quarter Challenge is announced in Week 5 and due the Sunday before Week 9 — one film per student, to a specific prompt rather than an open brief. Films are ranked together as a class in Week 9 against six craft criteria, published in Week 1:

- Best Audio
- Best Color and Grading
- Best Camera Work
- Best Editing Trick
- Best Story
- Bravest Idea

There is deliberately no overall "best film."

GRADING

Baseline is an A–, and grading is exception-based — most weeks nothing is recorded.

- Skill is graded on in-class work only, never on home films — home films get help from parents and groups, which makes them unfair to judge for craft.
- Home films count for participation only (submitted or not, never quality); the floor is two home submissions per quarter, and more is upside.
- Skill is observed during playback rather than live, with a few students looked at each week.

ADDITIONAL INFORMATION AND RESOURCES

Looking Ahead to Quarter 2

The Q2 film project is made from Part One of the hero's journey story each student writes in English during Q1. Each student chooses to film their own story alone, or join a group and film one member's story. Nobody is put in a group they did not choose, and nobody's story is used without them wanting it used — students are told this in Week 1 rather than at the end, so they write knowing a camera is coming.